

FUTURES AND PROP FIRMS

Futures Trading and Prop Firms

A clear guide to futures mechanics, evaluation rules, payout restrictions, and how to compare firm promotions without getting distracted by the headline discount.



BEFORE YOU BEGIN

The first distinction: futures trading is not prop-firm marketing

A futures contract is a standardized agreement traded on an exchange. A retail futures prop firm is a private company that offers an evaluation and then a rule-bound trading arrangement. Passing an evaluation does not make a contract less leveraged, and a firm label such as "funded" does not by itself tell you whether you are trading simulated or live capital.

EXCHANGE PRODUCT

Futures

Standard contract, tick size, multiplier, margin, and settlement rules.

FIRM PROGRAM

Evaluation

Private rules for targets, drawdowns, permitted behavior, and progression.

YOUR OBLIGATION

Due diligence

Read every rule, payout policy, fee, and disclosure before buying.

Risk warning

Regulators warn that speculative futures trading is volatile, complex, and often unsuitable for retail customers. A personal account can lose more than the initial investment; a prop evaluation fee may cap the immediate program cost, but it does not eliminate trading risk, recurring fees, or the risk that a payout request is denied under the program's rules.

How to use this guide

Use the firm pages as a vocabulary and due-diligence framework, not a ranking. Compare the exact program and account size you plan to buy. Rules frequently differ between evaluation, simulated funded, and live stages at the same firm.

CHAPTER 1

Futures trading in plain English

Futures are standardized contracts. Each product has a contract multiplier and a minimum price fluctuation, called a tick. Profit and loss are driven by price movement, tick value, and the number of contracts. Margin is a performance bond, not the full value of the contract.

The four numbers to know before any order

P/L per position = tick movement x tick value x number of contracts. Verify product specifications directly with the exchange and your broker.

MNQ EXAMPLE

Micro E-mini Nasdaq-100 futures have a smaller contract size than NQ. A quarter-point tick in MNQ is commonly worth \$0.50, while one full index point is \$2 per contract. Product specifications can change; confirm before trading.

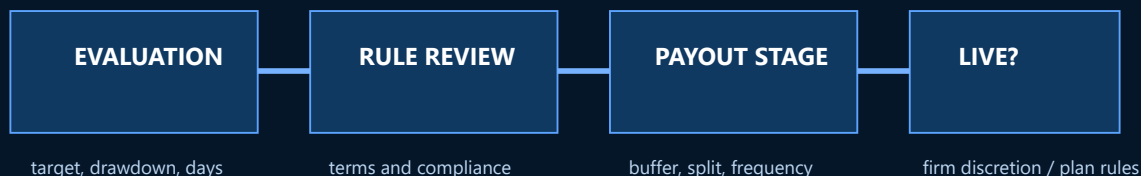
WHY THIS MATTERS

Fewer contracts reduce exposure. The maximum contracts a broker or prop firm allows are not a recommended size. CME emphasizes selecting contract count based on risk scenarios, not merely the maximum permitted.

CHAPTER 2

How a retail futures prop firm typically works

A common program path



The exact progression differs by program. Many firms use simulation before any possible live-capital transition.

- 1 Buy or subscribe to an evaluation.** You pay an upfront or recurring program fee and trade under stated objectives and limits.
- 2 Pass without breaking a rule.** A profit target alone is not enough if the account violates drawdown, time, consistency, behavior, or platform rules.
- 3 Read the funded-stage policy again.** Payout rules can be tighter or simply different from evaluation rules. Profit split, buffers, payout timing, scaling, and prohibited conduct are key.
- 4 Do not assume "funded" means live.** Check the agreement. A firm may use simulated performance first, may route some traders to live, or may reserve that decision for risk management.

CHAPTER 3

The rules that change your trade

TRAILING DRAWDOWN

A loss floor rises as the account reaches new highs. It may calculate intraday, using unrealized P/L, or only at end of day. Those versions create very different risk buffers.

END-OF-DAY DRAWDOWN

The drawdown line adjusts from an end-of-session value. It can be less sensitive to intraday unrealized peaks, but it is still a hard rule when measured.

DAILY LOSS LIMIT

A daily loss threshold can stop trading for the day, pause the account, or be a breach depending on the program. Do not assume it is the same as maximum drawdown.

CONSISTENCY RULE

Firms may limit the largest winning day as a percentage of total profits. Usually this does not change the original target; it can require additional profitable days before passing or withdrawing.

Other rules that matter just as much

Minimum trading days

Contract scaling

News / overnight limits

Copy trading rules

Inactivity

Payout buffer

Prohibited strategies

Account caps

Do not use the drawdown as the stop loss

Several firms expressly prohibit treating the full threshold as a trade-level stop. Keep an independent trade risk limit that is materially smaller than the remaining account buffer.

CHAPTER 4

Six program snapshots: compare the rule design, not the account label

These are selected, official-site examples checked August 17, 2026. They are not standardized products or a ranking. A firm may offer multiple plans with different terms; verify the account page and agreement before purchase.

Firm / selected path	Evaluation example	Key rule emphasis	Funded-stage note
Topstep 50K Trading Combine	\$3,000 target; \$2,000 maximum loss limit; 5 mini / 50 micro maximum.	50% Combine consistency target. The current page describes one hard MLL rule plus objectives.	Payout path can use five \$150 winning days or a 40% consistency option; account-path fees differ.
MyFundedFutures Pro	Plan-specific evaluation; check exact account page.	Firm advertises EOD trailing drawdown, a professional-consistency policy, and no funded daily loss limit on Pro.	Firm says Pro live review can follow three consecutive payouts or a \$20K profit milestone, subject to risk review.
Take Profit Trader 50K	\$3,000 target; 6 mini / 60 micro limit.	Official site shows \$2,000 EOD trailing drawdown and no daily loss limit; other behavior rules apply.	PRO uses an 80/20 split; site describes a possible PRO+ live path with EOD drawdown and 90/10 split.
Apex Legacy 50K PA	Legacy signup pages show \$3,000 target and \$2,500 trailing threshold.	Legacy PA material describes 30% payout consistency, a safety-net balance, and contract scaling before the threshold is cleared.	Legacy payout page states an eight-trading-day cadence and plan-specific payout caps. Verify the current plan, not only legacy pages.
Earn2Trade TCP25	\$1,750 goal; \$1,500 EOD drawdown; \$550 daily loss limit; up to 3 contracts.	Official program page describes a 30% consistency limit and 10 minimum days on one version of the plan.	Program describes LiveSim and live paths, a progression ladder, and an 80% trader split on the selected page.
Lucid Trading 50K Pro	\$3,000 target; \$2,000 EOD MLL; up to 4 minis or 40 micros.	MLL follows the highest end-of-day close and locks at \$50,100 after the stated trail. LucidPro payouts use a 40% consistency limit.	Official payout page lists a 90/10 split, \$500 minimum profit per cycle, a buffer, and plan-specific payout caps.

Read the qualifiers

"No daily loss limit" does not mean no maximum loss. "No activation fee" does not mean no recurring fee. "Daily payouts" can still have buffers, consistency, minimum profit, compliance, or risk-review conditions.

CHAPTER 5

What the comparison means in practice

Same \$50K label, different risk path



Illustration only. Always use the firm's defined calculation, including treatment of commissions, open P/L, and reset timing.

FOR SMALL-TARGET SCALPERS

A low daily-loss limit, a tight intraday trailing floor, or a consistency rule may change whether the strategy fits the program even if the account size looks large.

FOR MULTI-HOUR TRADERS

Overnight flat rules, news restrictions, an intraday drawdown that follows open profits, or a required close time may matter more than the advertised profit split.

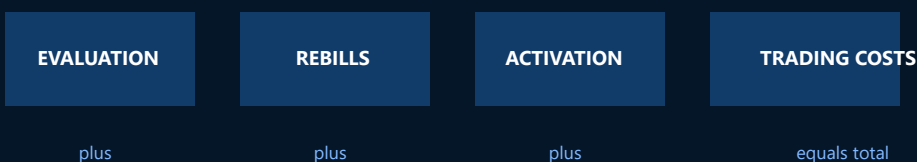
Pick the rule set that matches the risk behavior your strategy already has. Do not reshape a weak strategy around a discount.

CHAPTER 6

Discounts and promotions: calculate the all-in cost

Promotions are volatile. A percentage-off offer can reduce the first bill while leaving a recurring subscription, reset charge, activation fee, data cost, tax, or funded-stage fee unchanged. Compare total cost through your planned path, not just the banner price.

All-in cost worksheet



Add any likely reset, platform/data, commission, exchange, tax, and payout-related costs your program displays. Do not assume all are included.

Official promotions located during this review

Topstep: its pricing page lists an ongoing Responsible Trading Discount at checkout for selected No Activation Fee Combine paths: \$10 off 50K, \$20 off 100K, and \$30 off 150K when adding the stated daily loss limit. It also lists \$50 off eligible Back2Funded reactivation with the stated DLL.

MyFundedFutures: its Pro page displays a price "based on current promotions" but does not publish a universal code or permanent percentage on that page.

CHAPTER 7

Promotion tracker: offers to verify

Firm	Official-page finding	How to use it responsibly
Topstep	Specific, ongoing DLL-linked checkout discounts are described on the official pricing page. General promo codes are profile-specific and normally apply only to the first month unless stated otherwise.	Record the normal price, the discounted price, the activation path, and the next rebill before purchase.
MyFundedFutures	Pro page says the displayed starting price is based on current promotions. Official payout help directs traders to stay updated with coupon codes, but no universal offer was stated on the reviewed page.	Treat the displayed checkout price as a snapshot; do not budget around an assumed future coupon.
Take Profit Trader	Two official promotional landing pages retrieved during this review conflicted: one advertised NOFEE40 for 40% lifetime discount; another advertised NEWYEAR50 for 50% lifetime discount.	Because the official landing pages differ, verify the active code, expiration, plan eligibility, and activation-fee treatment in checkout. Do not rely on either figure after this review date.
Apex	No current, permanent official promotion was located in the rules pages reviewed. Many third-party or referral coupon pages exist.	Do not treat affiliate coupons as a program rule. Review the official checkout and current agreement.
Earn2Trade	Official program pages display plan price and terms; a search result included an affiliate-linked discount parameter, not a universal public offer.	Use the direct official product page and confirm the final cart total. Do not infer a lasting 60% offer from a referral link.
Lucid Trading	LucidMaxx pricing help says its evaluations have no discounts. A separate Lucid product page showed a coupon-based LucidPro price, which is a different path.	Do not generalize one path's offer to another. Confirm the product, base price, code, reset price, and activation treatment in the direct checkout.

A "lifetime" discount still needs a definition: which plan, which account size, which rebills, which data feed, which activation fee, and what happens after a reset?

CHAPTER 8

A prop-firm due-diligence checklist

BEFORE PAYING

- ✓ Open the exact account-size rule page and agreement.
- ✓ Record the target, drawdown, daily loss, minimum days, position cap, and trading hours.
- ✓ Price the normal bill, promotion, rebill, reset, activation, data, tax, and commission.
- ✓ Confirm cancellation and refund treatment before entering card details.

BEFORE REQUESTING PAYOUT

- ✓ Confirm the profit minimum, buffer, consistency calculation, and cadence.
- ✓ Check whether commissions, open P/L, or a new peak changes eligibility.
- ✓ Review prohibited conduct, copy-trading, and account-consolidation rules.
- ✓ Save the current rule page and dated dashboard evidence.

Questions customer support should answer in writing

DRAWDOWN

Is the threshold realized balance, intraday equity, or end-of-day balance? Does it stop trailing? Are commissions included?

PAYOUT

What are the minimum, maximum, buffer, day count, consistency rule, and compliance-review steps for this plan?

PROMOTION

Does the code apply only to the first bill? Does it waive activation? Does it survive a reset or upgrade?

LIVE STATUS

When does the program become live, who decides, and what terms change after the transition?

CHAPTER 9

Risk plan for a prop evaluation

Build trade risk from the remaining permitted loss, not from the profit target. A simple approach is to set a personal daily stop and a per-trade maximum that leave room for normal variance. Those numbers should be stricter than the program's hard breach level.

Illustrative risk ladder

FIRM MAXIMUM LOSS - NEVER YOUR TRADE STOP

PERSONAL DAILY STOP

SETUP RISK BUDGET

PER-TRADE RISK

The amounts and spacing are illustrative. Set personal limits based on tested strategy behavior, account economics, and the exact firm calculation.

Rules do not turn speculation into income

Risk limits can make a trading process more controlled, but they cannot create positive expectancy. Do not use a prop evaluation to test an unproven system, recover losses, or trade money needed for living expenses.

SOURCES AND FINAL NOTES

Official resources to re-check before you buy

Rules and offers can change without notice. Re-check the direct official pages below, then compare them with the agreement and checkout screen for the precise plan you select.

CFTC, Futures Market Basics: <https://www.cftc.gov/LearnAndProtect/AdvisoriesAndArticles/FuturesMarketBasics/index.htm>

CME Group, Position and Risk Management: <https://www.cmegroup.com/education/courses/things-to-know-before-trading-cme-futures/position-and-risk-management>

Topstep, Trading Combine Parameters: <https://help.topstep.com/en/articles/8284197-trading-combine-parameters>

Topstep, Pricing and Payment Questions: <https://help.topstep.com/en/articles/14289835-topstep-pricing-and-payment-questions>

MyFundedFutures, Pro Plan: <https://myfundedfutures.com/plans/pro>

MyFundedFutures, Consistency Rule: <https://help.myfundedfutures.com/en/articles/11994562-consistency-rule-at-my-funded-futures>

Take Profit Trader, Futures Traders: <https://try.takeprofittrader.com/futures-traders-tabgoogle-0725>

Take Profit Trader, Current Program Overview: <https://takeprofittrader.com/>

Apex, Legacy PA Payout Parameters: <https://apextraderfunding.com/help-center/legacy-payouts/legacy-pa-payout-parameters/>

Earn2Trade, Trader Career Path: <https://www.earn2trade.com/trader-career-path>

Lucid Trading, LucidPro Drawdown: <https://support.lucidtrading.com/en/articles/12890136-lucidpro-drawdown>

Lucid Trading, LucidPro Payouts: <https://support.lucidtrading.com/en/articles/12890092-lucidpro-payouts>

Educational disclaimer

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The best promotion is not necessarily the lowest first payment. It is the program whose rules, costs, and risk constraints you fully understand before your first order.